

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper 1 Simulation

QUESTION PAPER | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

INSTRUCTIONS

1. The paper has two sections, A and B, and eight questions.
2. Question 1 and Question 5 are compulsory.
3. Answer three other questions, choosing at least one from each section.
4. Answer five questions in all. The marks carried by each subpart are indicated.

SECTION A - Western Philosophy

Q1 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) "Percepts without concepts are blind and concepts without percepts are empty." In the light of this statement discuss how Kant reconciles rationalism with empiricism. [10 marks]
- (b) "An ostensive definition can be variously interpreted in every case." Examine the significance of this remark for Wittgenstein's account of meaning. [10 marks]
- (c) "Ideas are timeless and spaceless." Elucidate this statement with reference to Plato. [10 marks]
- (d) Distinguish Hegel's true infinite from the bad infinite, and explain why the distinction is required by Absolute Idealism. Discuss. [10 marks]
- (e) Can hallucination be regarded as an intentional act by Husserl? Explain. [10 marks]

Q2

- (a) "Kant's Transcendental Deduction is the strongest anti-sceptical argument in modern philosophy and rests on its weakest scaffolding." Critically examine. [20 marks]
- (b) "The Second Analogy defeats Hume at the level of entitlement but not at the level of knowledge." Examine this claim. [15 marks]
- (c) "But could we also imagine a language in which a person could write down or give vocal expression to his inner experiences-his feelings, moods and the rest-for his private use?" Critically discuss the answer offered by Wittgenstein to this question. [15 marks]

Q3

- (a) "We should look not to an ideal language which derives its meaning from facts and has a precise 'logical structure but empirically, to the ways in which languages are actually used." Explain the transition from early views of Wittgenstein to his later views on language and meaning with reference to this statement. [20 marks]
- (b) "The Categories and Metaphysics VII (Z) give different answers because they ask different questions." Critically examine this resolution of Aristotle's account of substance. [15 marks]
- (c) Assess the view that Hegel's identification of the rational with the actual makes his philosophy a defence of the existing order. [15 marks]

Q4

- (a) Compare Plato's and Aristotle's metaphysics of form, and evaluate whether Aristotle's immanentism is an advance on Plato's transcendence. [20 marks]
- (b) Elucidate the significance of bracketing and reduction in Husserl's phenomenological method. [15 marks]
- (c) Among the rationalists, whose account of mind-body problem is compatible with the notion of human freedom and free will? Critically discuss. [15 marks]

SECTION B - Indian Philosophy

Q5 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) Do these two sentences "Air does not have heat" and "Air is not fire" refer to the same type of absence or abhava, according to the Vaisesikas? Discuss. [10 marks]
- (b) "In Jainism the moral quality of an act is fixed by passion rather than by activity." Examine this claim with reference to the parameters of bondage. [10 marks]
- (c) Distinguish between pudgala-nairatmyavada and dharma-nairatmyavada with reference to Buddhist Philosophy. [10 marks]
- (d) How does Bhatta's view of nature of word-meaning and sentential-meaning differ from Prabhakara's view? Critically discuss. [10 marks]
- (e) Explain the two senses of the Middle Path (madhyama pratipad) in Buddhism. Why is the doctrinal sense indispensable to the practical one? [10 marks]

Q6

- (a) Elucidate Naiyayikas account of fallacies of the middle term in relation to five characteristics of valid middle term. [20 marks]
- (b) Critically evaluate the logical and metaphysical status of Visesa in the context of Vaisesika Philosophy. [15 marks]
- (c) "Jaina non-violence is a metaphysical consequence, not a sentiment." Critically discuss with reference to the doctrine of the soul and the mechanics of bondage. [15 marks]

Q7

- (a) 'Brahma satyam jaganmithya, Jivo Brahmaiva naparah'. In the light of this statement explain the ontological status of Isvara, Jiva and Saksi as elucidated in Advaita Vedanta. [20 marks]
- (b) Analyse the four schools of Buddhism as an argumentative escalation rather than as a classification. What does each successive position gain and lose? [15 marks]
- (c) Discuss the debate between the Bhatta and the Prabhakara mimamsakas with reference to the nature of Non-existence (Abhava) and its knowledge. [15 marks]

Q8

- (a) How do the Naiyayikas prove the existence of God? Do the Yoga philosophers prove God in the same way? If yes, how? And if no, why? Give reasons for your answer. [20 marks]
- (b) Examine the Jaina claim that ordinary sense-perception is only conventionally direct. What does this reveal about the relation between Jaina epistemology and Jaina soteriology? [15 marks]
- (c) Explain the nature of God and its role in Kaivalya in yoga philosophy. [15 marks]

END OF PAPER